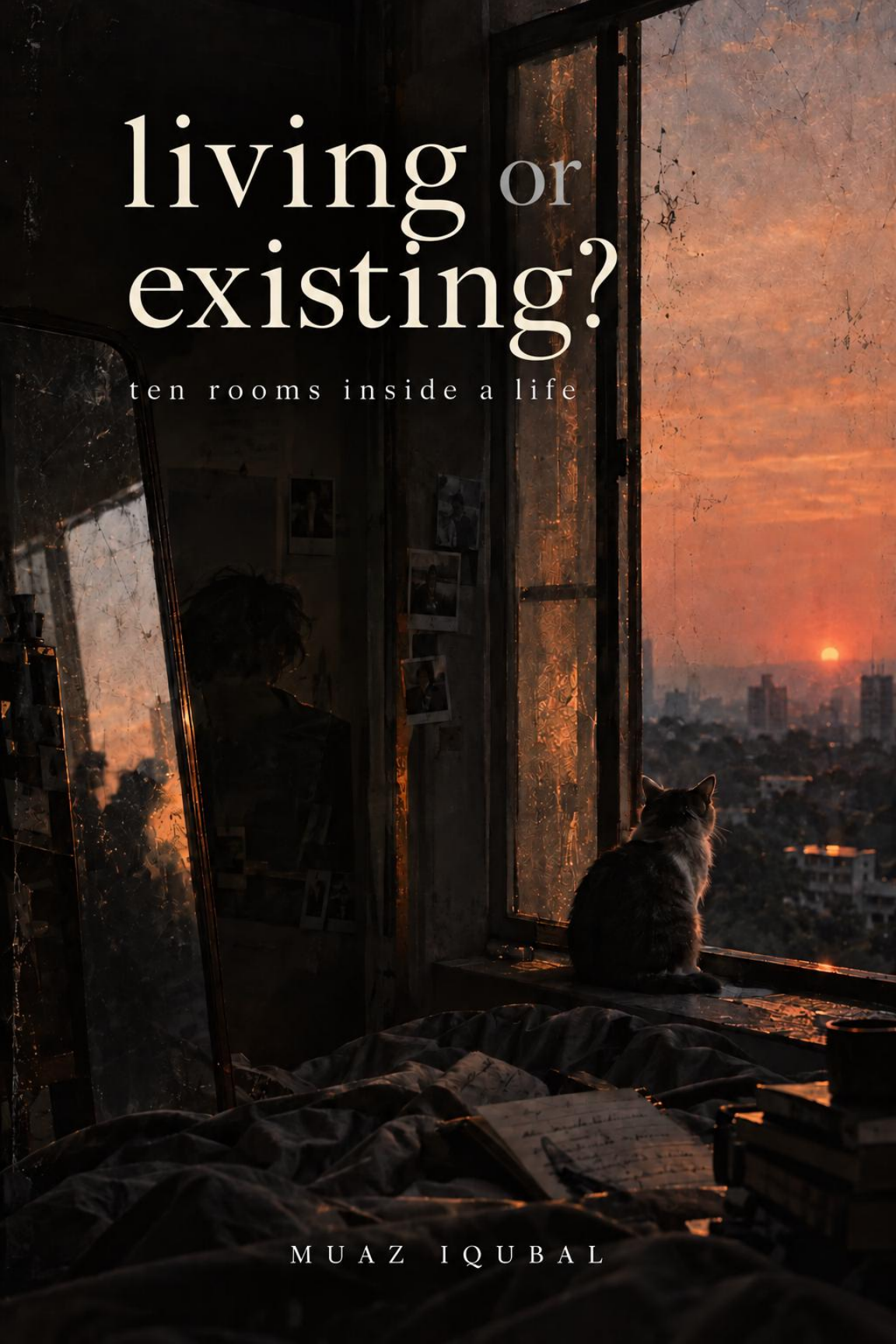

living or existing?
ten rooms inside a life
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First assembled edition

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Prologue — The Question

There are days when a person wakes up and discovers that the machinery of being alive has continued without asking permission.

The heart has beaten through the night. The lungs have done their work. The morning has arrived exactly when it was supposed to. Somewhere outside, a vehicle passes. Someone makes breakfast. A phone lights up. A message waits.

Nothing has happened.

And yet something has.

There is a peculiar violence in discovering that the body can continue long after the mind has stopped understanding why it should.

I have spent a long time trying to name that distance.

Living.

Existing.

The words look almost identical until you place them beside a mirror.

Then they become opposites.

This book is not an answer. It is a collection of rooms I have stood inside while trying to understand the difference. Some rooms are crowded. Some contain only a mirror. Some contain a flower that cannot remember where it bloomed. Some contain a four-legged creature who understood love better than I did.

And some contain nothing except a closing window.

I wrote these pieces at different times, but they were always speaking to one another.

I simply did not know it yet.

I — All While I Was Burning Myself Away

The mind is a strange machine.

It can contain an entire world while the body sits motionless in a chair.

Thoughts turn like independent wheels. One asks where consciousness comes from. Another asks where it is going. A third wonders whether there was ever a destination at all.

We build roads because we are frightened of standing still.

Then we spend our lives choosing between them.

Some roads are given to us before we are old enough to question them. Others appear after failure, after love, after loss, after the quiet realization that the person walking is no longer the person who began.

I used to think direction was the same thing as purpose.

It isn't.

A person can move for years and still arrive nowhere.

Perhaps that is what burning means.

Not destruction.

Consumption.

The slow use of oneself in exchange for movement.

You wake. You work. You speak. You laugh at the right places. You answer messages. You make plans. You postpone the important questions because there is always another day available to ask them.

And while all of that happens, something inside you becomes ash.

The frightening part is not noticing the fire.

It is noticing how warm it is.

For a while, you mistake the burning for life.

II — The Loneliest Crowd

There is a particular kind of loneliness that becomes visible only when surrounded by people.

A room full of laughter can be more frightening than an empty room.

Everyone seems to possess an instruction manual for being alive. They know when to laugh. They know where to stand. They know what to want. They carry their futures like documents already signed.

I stood among them and saw ghosts.

Not because they were dead.

Because I could not reach them.

The crowd becomes cruel when you are already measuring yourself against it. Every conversation becomes a comparison. Every success becomes an accusation. Every ordinary happiness asks why yours feels so far away.

Perhaps this is where expectations begin to become cages.

The people who love us want something from us.

Sometimes that something is beautiful.

Sometimes it is simply survival.

Sometimes it becomes a weight.

A child learns to recognize disappointment before learning to recognize himself. A young person begins to fear mediocrity before understanding what a meaningful life might look like. Eventually, failure stops being an event and becomes an identity.

You stop saying, “I failed.”

You begin saying, “I am a failure.”

The crowd does not have to say it.

You have already learned how.

III — The Collector of Failures

I began collecting failures without realizing I was building a museum.

Some were small enough to hide.

Some were too large.

There were failures that belonged to me, failures I inherited, failures I imagined, and failures that existed only because I had compared myself with somebody else.

I carried them all.

The strange thing about failure is that it rarely arrives alone. It brings memory with it.

A room.

A face.

A sentence.

A look in someone's eyes.

A version of yourself you wish you could return to.

Eventually, the collection becomes heavier than the person carrying it.

And then there is grief.

Grief does not always announce itself as crying. Sometimes it is irritation. Sometimes it is silence. Sometimes it is the sudden realization that an ordinary object in a room has become sacred because someone who loved it is no longer here.

There are losses for which language is too small.

So I started writing around them.

I wrote about red against white. About the cold. About a body becoming still. About the absurdity of the world continuing to behave normally while something inside you has stopped.

The world does not pause for grief.

Dinner still needs to be eaten.

Messages still arrive.

The next morning still comes.

Forty steps away from death, someone can still be deciding what to have for dinner.

That is not cruelty.

It is existence.

Perhaps the most brutal thing about being alive is that life keeps asking you to participate.

IV — The Flower That Forgot Where It Bloomed

Some things disappear without ever becoming ugly.

That is what makes them difficult to mourn.

A flower can be beautiful and still be temporary.

A memory can be perfect and still be inaccessible.

A person can matter enormously and still become a story someone tells years later.

I once imagined that if I could hold tightly enough to a thing, I could prevent it from changing.

That was the childish bargain.

If I remembered enough, loved enough, waited enough, perhaps the universe would understand that I was not ready to lose anything.

But flowers do not negotiate.

They bloom where they can.

They absorb whatever the soil gives them.

They open toward whatever light reaches them.

And then, eventually, they fall.

Perhaps the flower did not forget where it bloomed.

Perhaps I did.

Perhaps I kept asking the dead to return to places that existed only in my memory.

The older I became, the more I understood that memory is not preservation.

It is transformation.

Every time we remember something, we change it slightly.

We turn a person into an image.

A place into a feeling.

A moment into a sentence.

And eventually, even grief becomes part of the person we are.

The flower is gone.

But something of its shape remains in the hand that once held it.

V — The Mirror That Knows Me

The mirror is one of the cruelest inventions.

It shows you a face and lets you decide what it means.

Some mornings, it is only a face.

Other mornings, it becomes evidence.

Evidence of failure.

Evidence of exhaustion.

Evidence that time has been moving even when you have been standing still.

I have looked at myself and wondered whether the reflection belonged to me or to everyone who had ever expected something from me.

The mirror does not judge.

That is precisely why it is frightening.

It only returns what you bring to it.

A person who hates himself can find hatred in perfect glass.

A person searching for proof of failure will always find something.

And yet there is freedom in that realization.

The reflection is not the self.

It is only an image.

The expectations are not the self either.

Neither are the grades, the victories, the losses, the opinions, the roles, the names.

There is a person beneath all of them.

I spent too long trying to become the person I thought I was supposed to be.

Perhaps the real tragedy is not failing to become that person.

Perhaps it is succeeding.

Because then you may wake one morning wearing a life that fits perfectly and still discover that it was never yours.

VI — Agony With No Address

Pain does not always have an address.

Sometimes there is no room where it lives, no person responsible for it, no single event that can be pointed toward.

It simply exists.

A low hum beneath the tongue.

A pressure behind the ribs.

Something that follows you from one room to another because there is nowhere you can leave it.

We become inventive when we are desperate to escape ourselves.

We find distractions.

We find substances.

We find screens.

We find people.

We find noise.

Anything is preferable to the silence in which the mind can hear itself.

But the escape eventually becomes another room.

Then another.

Then a hallway with no doors.

The tragedy of addiction is not merely the thing consumed.

It is the bargain underneath it.

For a moment, something answers.

Not the question.

Just the pain.

And that can be enough.

A person does not always want to disappear.

Sometimes they simply want the version of themselves that hurts to stop speaking.

The world rarely knows the difference.

It sees behaviour.

It sees mistakes.

It sees the aftermath.

It does not always see the addressless agony that came first.

VII — The Behavioral Sink

At some point I stopped asking only what was wrong with me.

I started asking what was wrong with the room.

John B. Calhoun's behavioral-sink experiments have stayed with me because they offer an uncomfortable metaphor: what happens when a population has enough physical resources, yet something about its social environment begins to collapse?

Modern life has solved many problems and created others that are harder to name.

We are connected almost constantly.

We are also increasingly difficult to reach.

We can see hundreds of lives before breakfast.

We compare ourselves with strangers we will never meet.

We are interrupted by notifications, measured by numbers, rewarded by attention, and trained to confuse visibility with value.

The crowd has moved inside the phone.

There is no longer a need to enter a room to feel excluded from it.

Perhaps the modern behavioral sink is not a place.

Perhaps it is an attention economy.

A system in which everyone is visible and almost nobody feels seen.

And perhaps the individual crisis and the social crisis are not separate.

Maybe the lonely person is not simply broken.

Maybe the room has been built to make loneliness profitable.

That possibility frightened me more than the mirror ever did.

VIII — My Beloved Four Legs

Of everything I have written, this is the room I return to most carefully.

Because grief becomes different when the person you lost never asked you to become anything.

He only existed.

Four legs.

A body that could cross a room and make the room feel less empty.

There was no expectation attached to his love.

No grade.

No achievement.

No future version of me that had to be worthy of it.

Only presence.

That is perhaps why losing him hurt differently.

I could carry every failure I had ever committed and still walk into a room where he was waiting.

For a while, that was enough.

In the strange landscape of grief, I imagined seeing him beyond a boundary I could not cross.

He called.

I could not follow.

And for the first time, I understood that love can be a reason to stay behind.

Not because the pain disappears.

Because something beautiful existed.

Something existed without demanding an explanation.

He did not need me to succeed.

He did not need me to become extraordinary.

He only needed me to be there.

Perhaps that is the lesson I failed to learn from people and learned from four legs:

being alive does not always require becoming someone.

Sometimes it requires remaining long enough to love what is already there.

IX — Reflection

There is a moment when the noise becomes distant.

The room continues.

The world continues.

The body continues.

But something inside becomes quiet enough to see itself.

That is the danger of reflection.

Not the mirror.

The honesty.

I have spent years fearing mediocrity as though it were a disease.

I measured myself against imaginary futures. I turned expectations into verdicts. I mistook achievement for permission to exist.

And somewhere in that process, I stopped asking the simplest question:

What do I actually want?

The answer was not success.

It was not recognition.

It was not becoming impressive enough to silence every disappointed face.

It was something much smaller.

Peace.

A room in which I did not have to perform.

A life that did not need to justify its existence every morning.

The mirror can be broken.

The reflection can scatter.

But every fragment still contains an image.

Perhaps identity works the same way.

We spend years trying to see ourselves whole.

Maybe we are never whole.

Maybe we are only fragments that happen to remember one another.

And perhaps that is enough.

X — A Closing Window

The window closes slowly.

That is the thing nobody tells you.

Death does not have to arrive like a door being slammed.

Sometimes it is a series of small closures.

A possibility you stop considering.

A person you stop calling.

A version of yourself you stop believing could exist.

A morning you no longer look forward to.

A window.

Then another.

And another.

Until the room becomes familiar.

I once thought purpose had to be something enormous.

A reason worthy of a life.

But perhaps living itself is the first purpose.

The alternative is only a body beneath a stone, a beginning date and an ending date, while the world continues several streets away.

The dead do not watch the living remember them.

Memory is for the living.

That used to frighten me.

Now I think perhaps it is simply how existence works.

We borrow one another for a while.

We leave marks.

We carry marks.

We lose people.

We become people who lost them.

We fail.

We succeed.

We begin again.

And through all of it, the window keeps closing.

Not because life is meaningless.

Because it is finite.

Maybe finiteness is what gives a moment its weight.

Maybe the point is not to keep the window open forever.

Maybe the point is to notice the light before it disappears.

Epilogue — Living or Existing?

I began with a question because I did not know how to begin with an answer.

Living or existing?

After everything, I still do not know.

But I know that existence is not empty simply because it is temporary.

The body will fail.

Memory will distort.

Names will disappear.

The people who knew us will eventually become stories told by people who never met us.

And still:

someone will laugh in another room.

A flower will open without knowing who planted it.

A stranger will look into a mirror and wonder who they are.

A tired person will come home and find an animal waiting.

Someone will fail and try again.

Someone will lose someone and discover that grief is another form of love.

Someone will sit beside a closing window and, for reasons they cannot explain, decide to stay.

Perhaps that is living.

Not having solved existence.

Not having defeated failure.

Not becoming immortal.

Just noticing.

The room.

The mirror.

The crowd.

The flower.

The grief.

The four legs.

The window.

The small, stubborn light.

And then opening the door.

Not because the world finally became kind.

But because it was still there.

And so were you.

For now.

Author's Note

This book is a reimagined, continuous work built from the themes, images, questions, and emotional architecture of the author's published pieces. The original Medium essays remain their own works; this manuscript reshapes their ideas into a single narrative rather than reproducing them verbatim.

The recurring question is deliberately left unresolved: living or existing?